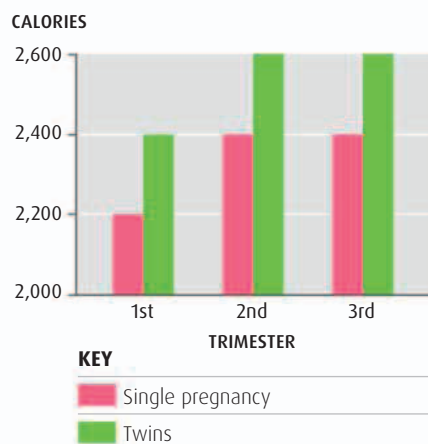


Q What does “eating for two” mean exactly? If I’m having twins, do I need to eat for three?

The adage “eating for two” does not mean that you need to eat twice as much as you did before you got pregnant. You just need a small increase in calories, and slightly more still if you are carrying twins or triplets.

If you are pregnant with one child, your optimal calorie intake during pregnancy should increase by only 200 daily calories during the first trimester, and by 300 daily calories during the second and third trimesters. The list of suggested snacks (right) shows what 200 calories looks like in practice. If you are carrying multiples, you should increase your calorie intake per baby. So, for twins, you need to add 400 calories at the start of your pregnancy and 600 calories during the middle and the final stages of pregnancy. The other crucial thing to remember is that you need to optimize the nutritional value of the food you “share” with your growing baby, so try to ensure these extra calories are nutrient dense—don’t forget quality in your quantity.



Optimum calorie intake The recommended guidelines on this chart ensure that you will give yourself and your baby enough nutrients and energy.

Make sure that the small increase in extra calories you need to eat during pregnancy are **nutrient dense** so that you have **quality in your quantity**.

CALORIE EQUIVALENT

How can I eat an extra 200–600 calories? Choose from these options or look for other healthy alternatives.



200 calories =
 1 slice of bread and
 1½ tablespoons of
 peanut butter

APPROXIMATELY 200 CALORIES:

- » 4 tablespoons of trail mix
- » 4 tablespoons hummus and 4 baby carrots
- » Boiled egg and toast without butter

APPROXIMATELY 400 CALORIES:

- » 7 oz (200 g) low-fat yogurt and 1 apple
- » 7 oz (200 g) avocado on 1 slice of toast
- » Grilled-cheese sandwich

your baby’s father’s genes will come into play, too. If he is tall and broad, your baby may just as likely be long and heavy at birth—or somewhere in between the two of you. Tell your doctor if you or your partner were particularly small at birth and discuss whether anything in your family histories might be reason for concern in your own baby’s weight.

Q Do I have excessive cravings? I seem to want foods and drinks I’ve never thought of having.

If you are suddenly desperate for foods you may previously have had little interest in, you are following a typical pattern in pregnancy. During early pregnancy in particular, your senses seem to be heightened due to your high hormone

levels: you may crave new foods and find that others—including tea, coffee, or fast foods—become repellent. This may be due to your sense of smell being more sensitive or a strange, perhaps metallic, taste in your mouth. Some experts suggest that your taste buds play a role in how you interpret your body’s needs.

Nobody really knows what causes cravings in pregnancy since scientific studies cannot easily quantify or measure them. Some studies have suggested a potential link between certain cravings—salty foods such as olives, sour fruits like lemons, or vegetarians eating meat—and maternal diet deficiencies. However, researchers are unsure if a deficiency occurs because of abnormal eating habits in pregnancy, or the cravings occur because of a deficiency in your diet. Most cravings don’t represent a threat to you or your baby unless you have the condition pica, when you crave nonfood items such as clay.

If you have persistent **morning sickness**, have food **cravings** such as drinking milk only, or have **lost your appetite** in late pregnancy, don’t stress about whether your **baby is receiving enough** nutrients. **Stress** can prove to be more detrimental to you and your baby than **eating lightly** for a period of time.